

YIAN WANG

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Machine unlearning, causal representation learning, robustness and safety of LLMs, interpretability, and adversarial ML.

EDUCATION

University of Illinois Urbana Champaign, US
PhD in Computer Science

August 2023 - Present

University of Illinois Urbana Champaign, US
Master of Science in Computer Science
Grade Point Average: 4.0/4.0

August 2021 - May 2023

University of Science and Technology of China Hefei, China

September 2016 - June 2020

Bachelor of Science in physics and minor in Computer Science

Grade Point Average: 3.64/4.3 in physics, 4.17/4.3 in Computer Science

TOEFL iBT:Total:104, Reading: 27, Listening: 26, Speaking: 23, Writing: 28

GRE:Verbal: 158, Quantitative: 169, Analytical Writing: 3.5

PUBLICATIONS

- **Yian Wang**, Agam Goyal, Eshwar Chandrasekharan, Hari Sundaram. *Facts Without Rules: Boundary Metadata Collapse in Multi-Agent LLM Handoffs*. Findings of EMNLP 2026.
- Ali Ebrahimpour-Boroojeny*, **Yian Wang**¹, Hari Sundaram. *Unlearning Isn't Forgetting: Revealing Hidden Leakage in Class Unlearning Evaluations*. ICML 2026.
- **Yian Wang**, Yuen Chen, Agam Goyal, Hari Sundaram. *CausalDetox: Causal Head Selection and Intervention for Language Model Detoxification*. In Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: ACL 2026.
- Agam Goyal*, **Yian Wang**², Eshwar Chandrasekharan, Hari Sundaram. *From Plausible to Causal: Counterfactual Semantics for Policy Evaluation in Simulated Online Communities*. PoliSim@CHI, 2026. **Best Paper Nomination**.
- **Yian Wang**, Agam Goyal, Yuen Chen, Hari Sundaram. *State Contamination in Memory-Augmented LLM Agents*. arXiv preprint 2026.
- **Yian Wang**, Mukhil Shankar, Eshwar Chandrasekharan, Hari Sundaram. *The Chilling: Identifying Strategic Antisocial Behavior Online and Examining the Impact on Journalists*. In *Proceedings of the 19th ACM conference on computer-supported cooperative work & social computing (CSCW)*, 2025.
- **Yian Wang**, Jian Kang, Yinglong Xia, Jiebo Luo, Hanghang Tong. iFiG: Individually Fair Multi-view Graph Clustering. In 2022 IEEE International Conference on Big Data (Big Data), 2022.
- Hongtao Liu, **Yian Wang**, Qiyao Peng, Fangzhao Wu, Lin Gan, Lin Pan, Pengfei Jiao. Hybrid neural recommendation with joint deep representation learning of ratings and reviews. *Neurocomputing*, 374, 77-85, 2020.

¹* Equal contribution.

²* Equal contribution.

- Hongtao Liu, **Yian Wang**, Fangzhao Wu, Pengfei Jiao, Hongyan Xu, Xing Xie. REKER: relation extraction with knowledge of entity and relation. In Natural Language Processing and Chinese Computing: 8th CCF International Conference, NLPCC, 2019.
- Agam Goyal, Vedant Rath, William Yeh, **Yian Wang**, Yuen Chen, Hari Sundaram. Breaking Bad Tokens: Detoxification of LLMs Using Sparse Autoencoders. In Actionable Interpretability Workshop at ICML 2025.

*Equal contribution.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

University of Illinois Urbana Champaign

Aug. 2023 - Present

Mentor: Dr. Hari Sundaram and Dr. Varun Chandrasekaran

- Agent Safety: Develop methods to understand, evaluate, and mitigate privacy and security risks in LLM-based multi-agent systems.
- Machine Unlearning: Design efficient algorithms for trustworthy data, class, and concept unlearning in foundation models with strong utility and privacy guarantees.
- Concept Entanglement: Study concept representations and entanglement in foundation models to enable precise model editing, unlearning, and controllable generation.

University of Illinois Urbana Champaign

Aug. 2021 - May. 2023

Mentor: Dr. Hanghang Tong

- Conducted research on individually fair multi-view graph clustering.
- Conducted research on a fair graph learning model that is robust.

Microsoft Research Asia

May. - Aug. 2021

Mentor: Dr. Fangzhao Wu

- Conducted a large-scale data collection.
- Conducted research and experiments on large-scale fair recommender systems for news recommendation.

University of Science and Technology of China

Sep. 2018 - May. 2020

Mentor: Dr. Qi Liu

- Conducted research on explainable recommender systems.
- Conducted research on representation learning for hybrid recommender systems.

WORKING EXPERIENCE

Pinterest

Seattle, WA

Machine Learning Internship

May. 2025 - Aug. 2025

- Designed and implemented novel candidate models to improve L1 ad ranking performance while keeping low latency.
- Conducted utility-based model tuning to balance user engagement and advertiser value.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Illinois Urbana Champaign

Urbana, IL

Teaching assistant

Aug. 2021 - Dec. 2021

- Teaching assistant of CS105: Intro Computing: Non-Tech.
- Supported students for Q&A and course logistics.
- Lead lab sessions.
- Instructor: Dr. Craig Zilles

University of Illinois Urbana Champaign

Teaching assistant

- Teaching assistant of CS412: Introduction to Data Mining.
- Assist with grading assignments and exams.
- Supervise students during office hours.
- Instructor: Dr. Hanghang Tong

Urbana, IL

Jan.2023 - May.2023